

The cage remembers everything

After making history as India's first UFC winner, Puja Tomar returns against Shi Ming with her **defensive frailties** firmly under the spotlight.

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Puja Tomar, who became the first-ever Indian to register a win in the Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC), will be in action on May 29.

But it is easy to overlook the bout while browsing through this year's UFC calendar. The reason is

that the fight falls under Road to UFC Season 5, which does not come under the traditional numbered events or Fight Nights.

Nonetheless, the fight holds significance for fans in India as Tomar looks for course correction. She will take on China's Shi Ming in a strawweight bout.

After a historic split-decision win on debut in 2024, Tomar was ground down and submitted via a second-round armbar by Shauna Bannon last year, highlighting a critical vulnerability in her defensive grappling.

Statistically, 'The Cyclone' lives up to her moniker. With 5.61 significant strikes per minute coupled with 49% accuracy, Tomar has taken the aggressive route more often than not. Operating from a southpaw stance, the five-time national wushu champion relies on lateral movement and sharp counter-punching combinations to dictate range. However, she absorbs an equally high 5.82 strikes per minute, signalling defensive gaps when pressured.

On the other hand, Shi Ming (17-6) will also be out to prove a point. After

Big ask: Puja Tomar (left) returns carrying equal parts promise, pressure and unfinished business. PICS: GETTY IMAGES

